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'SING ME A LULLABY': TENDERNESS AND TRANS MOTHERS IN THE WORK OF CAMILA SOSA VILLADA

Camila Sosa Villada's *Las malas* (2019), a tale of *travesti* sex workers in Córdoba, Argentina, was something of a publishing phenomenon, and its author (b. La Falda, Córdoba Province, 1982) has become perhaps the most recognized trans writer in Argentina.¹ A notable feature of her writing is its portrayal of trans or *travesti* mothers,² particularly in *Las malas*, an extended prose novel-cum-memoir, but also in the more recent collection of shorter and equally genre-defying pieces, *Soy una tonta por quererte* (2022).³ One specific feature of this portrayal is the reiterated presence of tenderness, *ternura*, and related affective and emotional terms, especially in her critical and commercial success, *Las malas*, the focus of this article. The mother-child relationship is the one place where we should expect to find tenderness, although, as we see in the work of Gabriela Mistral, for example, this is far from straightforward: *ternura* is many things and the term may possess multiple meanings. Tenderness incorporates the mental and the physical, emotional love and bodily vulnerability. As Joan Corominas reminds us, *ternura* in Spanish has its Latin roots in *tener* (soft, delicate, tender), and has links to meat and animals—*ternero*, calf, veal; *ternilla*, cartilage—as well as human emotions.⁴ Multiple forms of tenderness, emotional, physical, and often hard to describe, appear in Sosa's work, connected with *travesti* and other mothers. Tenderness can appear alongside sexual desire and intimacy, but also against a backdrop of, or even resulting from, violence and vulnerability. Furthermore, as will be argued, certain formal features of Sosa's writing turn the works themselves tender: porous, vulnerable, and, with the inclusion of fantastical elements,

I first wrote about Sosa Villada in collaboration with Jordana Blejmar for a book chapter, yet to be published. I am grateful to Jordana for her intellectual companionship and insight over the years in this and other projects, and to two anonymous reviewers for their helpful comments.

¹ Camila Sosa Villada, *Las malas* (Buenos Aires: Tusquets, 2019). References to this edition are given parenthetically in the text, with the abbreviation *LM*.

² There is a wealth of material on the use of these terms in a Latin American and specifically Argentine context. Very roughly, *travesti* would occupy (and potentially exceed) the space on a Venn diagram where the English terms 'transsexual' and 'transvestite' overlap. There are multiple reasons—cultural, political, medical—for the inaccurate match, for which reason the term *travesti* needs to be maintained when writing about Sosa's work. See e.g. Joseph Pierce, 'I Monster: Embodying Trans and Travesti Resistance in Latin America', *Latin American Research Review*, 55 (2020), 305–21 <<https://doi.org/10.25222/larr.563>>.

³ Camila Sosa Villada, *Soy una tonta por quererte* (Buenos Aires: Tusquets, 2022). By 'novel-cum-memoir', I mean that while one can read the work as imaginative fiction, at the same time elements clearly draw on and tell the real life of the author. As stated, this article focuses on *Las malas* (in part also for reasons of space), but both *Soy una tonta* and the similarly hybrid volume *La novia de Sandro* (first published 2015; repr. Buenos Aires: Tusquets, 2022) are worthy of further and more detailed study.

⁴ Joan Corominas, *Breve diccionario etimológico de la lengua castellana* (Madrid: Gredos, 1973), p. 567.

generically unstable. This article addresses tenderness in Sosa's work in the context of questions about the politics of motherhood and trans rights in contemporary Argentina. These are both live political issues in that country and beyond, while Sosa is one of the most visible and successful trans writers from Argentina. The formal and technical choices made in her work thus offer insights into the political potential of creative writing to destabilize literary genres while engaging in pressing debates about gender and human rights.

In her pioneering study *De donde vienen los niños*, Nora Domínguez assesses the at times paradoxical position of mothers in Argentine literature: while mothers traditionally occupied a 'lugar marginal', 'el relato de la maternidad acompaña, sostiene y atraviesa la cultura argentina', in which 'los hijos representan; las madres son representadas'.⁵ Recent Argentine fiction offers us many images of motherhood, layered and complex, and quite a few of them demonstrate a far from tender view of maternity. As Elsa Drucaroff puts it:

En la mirada machista de la modernidad psicoanalizada, la madre era sobre todo fuente de culpa y castración. Sin idealizarla, las nuevas sensibilidades de género postmodernas, narran otra veta: la potencia creadora de la madre, su enorme capacidad de curar.⁶

But other aspects of maternity, apart from creation and curing, are also very much present in contemporary narrative. In Gloria Peirano's study of a mother–daughter relationship, a novel deeply rooted in the politics of maternity in the wake of Peronist politics in Argentina, *La ruta de los hospitales*, motherhood appears as an illness, either benign or malign.⁷ Young writers such as Leila Sucari have explored non-idealized, contradictory experiences of motherhood. Sucari's *Fugaz* (2019) depicts the estranged relationship of a mother and her infant son.⁸ The novel begins with a brutal sentence—'La primera vez que lo vi me dio asco'—that destabilizes, from the outset, any naive myths about motherhood.⁹ Lucila Grossman's humorous novella *Mapas terminales* (2017) takes the estrangement between mother and child even further.¹⁰ Partly a diary of a female drug addict, partly conspiracy novel and 'trash science fiction', as defined by María Moreno, it tells the story of a woman who gives birth to a sort of alien with whom she communicates only through her computer.¹¹

Agustina Bazterrica's *Cadáver exquisito* (2018) depicts the exploitation of maternity on a mass and individual scale. In its dystopian near future, because

⁵ Nora Domínguez, *De donde vienen los niños: maternidad y escritura en la cultura argentina* (Rosario: Beatriz Viterbo, 2017), pp. 15–16.

⁶ Elsa Drucaroff, *Panorama Interzona* (Buenos Aires: Interzona, 2012), p. 231.

⁷ Gloria Peirano, *La ruta de los hospitales* (Buenos Aires: Alfaguara, 2019).

⁸ Leila Sucari, *Fugaz* (Buenos Aires: Tusquets, 2019).

⁹ *Ibid.*, p. 15.

¹⁰ Lucila Grossman, *Mapas terminales* (Buenos Aires: Marciana, 2017).

¹¹ María Moreno, back cover to Grossman, *Mapas terminales*.

of a mysterious virus infecting all animals, the production, sale, and consumption of human meat have been developed worldwide.¹² Tenderness is found either in moments that are harshly fleeting or in descriptions of the higher-quality—and often still living—*viands* on offer. In her poetry collection *Madre soltera* (2014), Marina Yuszczuk offers a stark insight into pregnancy and maternal labour.¹³ After this witty, self-deflating critique of the lyric confession, Yuszczuk returned to motherhood in a variety of forms through the lens of the vampire novel in *La sed* (2021); here it is again the flesh that is tender.¹⁴ Even in what might be called more mainstream fiction, albeit intellectually ambitious and socially engaged, the crime novels of Claudia Piñeiro have recently battled with the uncomfortable side of motherhood: ageing and illness in *Elena sabe* (2019); clandestine abortion and religious fanaticism in *Catedrales* (2020).¹⁵ All this within a wider literary context in which various forms of non-traditional maternity are explored and celebrated, as in, for example, Maggie Nelson's *The Argonauts* (2015) and the work of Jacqueline Rose (see below).¹⁶

Hinted at in Grossman's or Bazterrica's writing is maternity's relationship both to contemporary politics and to thinking about the relationship between the human and its others; in Laura Briggs's words, 'the politics of reproduction are key to understanding our shared political life'.¹⁷ Briggs is describing the situation in the US (and to an extent the UK), but there is much that resonates with these Argentine works. She writes: 'Reproductive politics are everywhere' and especially in 'demonized figures'.¹⁸ As Cynthia Francica puts it, contemporary trends in activism, politics, and academia '[open up] space to think through the physical and affective dimensions of motherhood in connection to the non-human'.¹⁹ She writes in the same piece, with reference to the fic-

¹² Agustina Bazterrica, *Cadáver exquisito* (Buenos Aires: Alfaguara, 2018).

¹³ Marina Yuszczuk, *Madre soltera* (Buenos Aires: Mansalva, 2014).

¹⁴ Marina Yuszczuk, *La sed* (Buenos Aires: Blatt & Ríos, 2021).

¹⁵ Claudia Piñeiro, *Elena sabe* (Buenos Aires: Alfaguara, 2019); *Catedrales* (Buenos Aires: Alfaguara, 2020).

¹⁶ Maggie Nelson, *The Argonauts* (London: Melville House, 2015). See also Miranda France, 'When Does the Guilt Start? Rethinking the Institution of Motherhood', *Times Literary Supplement*, 16 September 2022, pp. 3–5; Christine Henneberg, 'The Good Mother', *New York Review of Books*, 18 August 2022, pp. 53–56.

¹⁷ Laura Briggs, *How All Politics Became Reproductive Politics: From Welfare Reform to Foreclosure to Trump* (Oakland: University of California Press, 2018), p. 210.

¹⁸ *Ibid.*, p. 201. See also *Mother Reader: Essential Writings on Motherhood*, ed. by Moyra Davey (London: Seven Stories, 2001); Adrienne Rich, 'Anger and Tenderness', in *Mother Reader*, ed. by Davey, pp. 81–98; Griselda Pollock, 'Mother Trouble', *Studies in the Maternal*, 1.1 (2009), 1–31 <<https://doi.org/10.16995/sim.114>>; Stella Sandford, 'What Is Maternal Labour?', *Studies in the Maternal*, 3.2 (2011), 1–11 <<https://doi.org/10.16995/sim.63>>.

¹⁹ Cynthia Francica, 'Beyond the Human: Maternity, Affect, and Monstrous Lives in the Narrative of Argentine Writer Samanta Schweblin', in *Affect, Gender and Sexuality in Latin America: Gender, Development and Social Change*, ed. by Cecilia Macón and others (Basingstoke: Palgrave Macmillan, 2021), pp. 127–49.

tions of Samanta Schweblin, of the 'complex links between the affective and material dimensions of motherhood and the embodied biological functions that sustain life'.²⁰ Francica explores too the links between motherhood and the monstrous in Schweblin's writing, but equally pertinent might be works by the authors cited above.²¹

In her study of motherhood, Jacqueline Rose argues that it is 'the place in our culture where we lodge, or rather bury, the reality of our own conflicts, of what it means to be fully human'.²² Contemporary society, she states, 'make[s] mothers the objects of licensed cruelty, [and] we blind ourselves to the world's iniquities and shut down the portals of the heart'.²³ As we see in Sosa's work, this is never truer than when trans motherhood is involved; Rose writes of 'the sadism that mothers provoke', and Sosa's fiction highlights this in compelling and moving fashion.²⁴ As Rose later adds, 'motherhood can, and should, be one of the central means through which a historical moment reckons with itself'.²⁵ One can argue that despite, or perhaps because of, the obviously fantastical elements in Sosa's writing, this is even more the case. The socio-political aspect is at the forefront of Rose's concerns: 'Mothers, we might say, are the original subversives'.²⁶ Towards the end of her study, she examines the writings of Susan Stryker, 'trans activist and writer', and a case of trans birth, 'the ritual of transforming consciousness that heralded this new birth'.²⁷ Rose, in a sense, is optimistic, although acknowledging the particular prejudices and violence faced by trans mothers: 'it is only the radical disorientation of transgender that makes such an exuberant and painful crossing possible'.²⁸

In this context, an exploration of trans maternity becomes yet more pressing, and, in particular, the mothering carried out by the figure of the *travesti* in Argentina.²⁹ Sosa's work warrants detailed study for its literary qualities

²⁰ Ibid., p. 144.

²¹ See also Juana Roggero, 'Lo materno: espacio continuo, presente perpetuo', in *Historia feminista de la literatura argentina*, ed. by Laura Arnés and others, 6 vols (Córdoba: EDUVIM, 2002), v: *En la intemperie: poéticas de la fragilidad y la revuelta*, pp. 257–62.

²² Jacqueline Rose, *Mothers: An Essay on Love and Cruelty* (London: Faber & Faber, 2018), p. 1.

²³ Ibid., p. 2.

²⁴ Ibid., p. 24.

²⁵ Ibid., p. 17.

²⁶ Ibid., p. 18.

²⁷ Ibid., p. 203.

²⁸ Ibid., p. 204.

²⁹ See the pioneering study by Ben Sifuentes-Jáuregui, *Transvestism, Masculinity and Latin American Literature: Genders Share Flesh* (Basingstoke: Palgrave, 2002), and a later work by Vek Lewis, *Crossing Sex and Gender in Latin America* (Basingstoke: Palgrave Macmillan, 2010). Many of these issues were being explored in the 1970s and 1980s by Néstor Perlongher, as can be seen in the essays collected in *Prosa plebeya* (Buenos Aires: Colihue, 1997); for a more contemporary reading, see SaSa Testa, *Cuerpxs en fuga: las praxis de la insumisión* (Rada Tilly, Chubut: Espacio Hudson, 2018).

alone—without doubt *Las malas* is a compelling read. Her writing has been compared to that of Carson McCullers and Lucia Berlin, but it is, at the same time, closely affiliated with trans/*travesti* activists such as Lohana Berkins, Naty Menstrual, Marlene Wayar, and Susy Shock (the last two provide part of the back-cover blurb for the 2019 Tusquets Argentine edition of *Las malas*), all of them part of an ever growing corpus of what Daniel Gigena calls *travesti* or trans Argentine literature.³⁰ Sosa, though, is also something of a phenomenon: in 2019 alone, *Las malas* ran to four printings, and by the time of *Soy una tonta*'s release had been translated into ten languages. And she is a very visible literary figure, perhaps the most recognized *travesti* writer in Argentina, although in interviews she has shied away from adopting a spokesperson or 'vocera' role for this community. As Tamara Tenenbaum states, Sosa 'va enhebrando la relación entre palabra e identidad, verdad y cuerpo, escritura y conciencia de sí'.³¹ For Pablo Farneda, Sosa 'se ha convertido en los últimos años en una de las artistas más reconocidas en la escena travesti-trans y se ha posicionado en el mundo literario y teatro argentino'.³²

This is, no doubt, a complex and difficult moment for trans and *travesti* rights in Argentina (and neighbouring countries). On the one hand, there are powerful and often successful campaigns for *travesti* rights, visibility, and memory, and other campaigns (#NiUnaMenos, against femicides; or the 'Green Handkerchief' campaign for safe legal voluntary termination of pregnancy) in which *travestis* have taken full part, and progressive governments that have passed, for example, gender recognition and equal marriage legislation;³³ on the other, there are increasingly vocal conservative sectors, often backed by the Catholic Church or Evangelical groups, critical of so-called 'Gender Ideology', as well as a small but growing number of 'RadFem' groups critical of trans inclusion into women's struggles.³⁴ All of this takes place against a backdrop in which 'el odio' occupies a prominent place in politics and public discourse, as studied by Gabriel Giorgi and Ana Kiffer,

³⁰ Daniel Gigena, 'Escrituras trans y travestis', *Perfil*, 8 March 2010 <<https://www.perfil.com/noticias/cultura/escrituras-trans-y-travestis.phtml>> [accessed 19 July 2023].

³¹ Tamara Tenenbaum, 'Ella dice que fue así: recorridos disidentes en las crónicas de autoras del presente', in *Historia feminista de la literatura argentina*, ed. by Arnés and others, v, 243–56 (p. 253).

³² Farneda also sketches the history of Sosa's blog and the success of *Las malas*. See Pablo Farneda, 'Escrituras travesti-trans: ¿cómo hacerse un cuerpo propio?', in *Historia feminista de la literatura argentina*, ed. by Arnés and others, v, 425–50 (p. 440).

³³ A particular case is the Archivo de la Memoria Trans, from which the front cover photograph of *Las malas* is drawn. See e.g. Daniele Salerno, 'An Instituting Archive for Memory Activism: The Archivo de la Memoria Trans de Argentina', *Memory Studies* <<https://doi.org/10.1177/17506980221150900>>; and Patricio Simonetto and Merce Butierrez, 'The Archival Riot: Travesti/Trans* Audiovisual Memory Politics in Twenty-First-Century Argentina', *Memory Studies* <<https://doi.org/10.1177/17506980211073099>>.

³⁴ Estefanía Santoro, 'Separadas por el útero', *Página/12*, 11 September 2020 <<https://www.pagina12.com.ar/290972-separadas-por-el-utero>> [accessed 19 July 2023].

with particular vehemence reserved for, among others, ‘negros, travestis, [y] putas’.³⁵ Nor can one overlook the long-standing doubts from trans or *travesti* activists themselves over their relationship with the state. As Pierce observes:

In the precise moment when the state begins to offer new agency via stable-because-recognized gender categories, these artists have turned to the tactile embodiment of the monster to articulate their disavowal of normative categorization.³⁶

Pierce cites the Chilean *travesti* artist and activist Claudia Rodríguez, who affirms that, ‘Para las travestis reales el estado no puede existir.’³⁷ This clashes with the role of the state and society in maternity, as Domínguez puts it: ‘El niño, cuando es expulsado del cuerpo materno, es recibido por un sistema de prácticas que arman un relato’.³⁸ In Sosa’s work the benevolent state does not exist for its trans and many other characters. The state’s representatives at best ignore, at worst mock, brutalize, and extort money from Sosa and her companions; indeed, the first adult sexual experience of the narrator—explicitly Sosa—is as a result of coercion (in effect rape) by the police. Pierce notes the importance of knowledge about and through the body in *travesti* resistance:

This is knowledge accumulated through violence, joy, humour, desire, danger, the body as proliferation of ontological possibilities, orientations, even those reflections of oneself in the mirror, in different mirrors.³⁹

These different mirrors appear throughout Sosa’s work; and tenderness, *ternura*, is central. For Sosa, as stated in her prose text *El viaje inútil*, in part an account of her earliest memories of reading and writing, the image of her mother hearing her read for the first time creates ‘una pacto de ternura. La imagen de la ternura’.⁴⁰ And yet, writing and reading also mark the moment at which the child is separated for ever from her mother: ‘Llenar todo ese vacío de ternura que fue también su herencia con una hija travesti que se separó para siempre de ella cuando aprendió a leer y escribir.’⁴¹ Thus, motherhood, tenderness, and literature are intimately stitched together in Sosa’s work.

³⁵ Gabriel Giorgi and Ana Kiffer, *Las vueltas del odio: gestos, escrituras, políticas* (Buenos Aires: Eterna Cadencia, 2020), p. 62, emphasis original. See also Gabriel Giorgi, ‘Hacer concha: escrituras performáticas del odio y pedagogías públicas’, in *Historia feminista de la literatura argentina*, ed. by Arnés and others, v, 107–18.

³⁶ Pierce, ‘I Monster’, p. 306. See also Briggs on ‘queer and trans families and households [and how] their right to even be considered a family was explicitly challenged in the rhetoric of “family values”’ (*Reproductive Politics*, pp. 16–17). Briggs argues that, ‘As a reproductive politics issue, same-sex marriage facilitated the privatization of dependency in both a queerly affirming and profoundly conservative way’ (ibid., p. 187).

³⁷ Pierce, ‘I Monster’, p. 306.

³⁸ Domínguez, *De donde vienen*, p. 40.

³⁹ Pierce, ‘I Monster’, p. 316.

⁴⁰ Camila Sosa Villada, *El viaje inútil* (Córdoba: DocumentA/Escénicas, 2018), p. 23.

⁴¹ Ibid., p. 32.

Bad Girls; or, The Queens of Sarmiento Park

Las malas is, as the title might suggest, many things at once. Large sections offer something close to a memoir of Sosa's life: tough childhood, departure from home, interrupted studies, sex work, and an early career in theatre. That Sosa tells this in non-chronological fashion is an early hint, though, that this is not a traditional memoir. Other sections offer a realistic portrait of the lives of *travesti*, and other, street sex workers in the city of Córdoba in the early 2000s. At the centre of this is a tale of trans motherhood: the de facto and eventually *de jure* adoption by the unofficial leader of the group, an older *travesti*, La Tía Encarna, of an abandoned child, El Brillo de los Ojos. It offers a story with some very precise spatio-temporal co-ordinates: the town of Mina Clavero; Córdoba city; the year in which Cris Miró (the 'Evita de las travestis') first appeared on Argentine television; the fall of President Fernando de la Rúa; and evidently autobiographical marks of the author (the narrator is called Camila and she is from Córdoba province).

Las malas is far from being a purely autobiographical or even realist text, however. The book is peppered with fantastical and magical feats and characters: a wolf-woman; a mute *travesti* who turns into a bird; the ghostly 'headless men' ('Los Hombres Sin Cabeza', sub-Saharan African migrants to Argentina); and moments in which the figurative turns literal, of seeming hyperbole or wild exaggeration, that would not be out of place in a novel by Gabriel García Márquez or Isabel Allende. Sosa's writing constantly frustrates the expectations of the reader by locating the characters in a world of myth and fable. The members of this gang seem like distant descendants of Romulus and Remus, orphans more comfortable around forest creatures than humans. There are also echoes of indigenous myth (La Difunta Correa), the fairy tale (La Tía Encarna as the Good Fairy), and even of the body-horror genre (María la Muda's transformation). Furthermore, the novel is highly literary, both in its distinctive, often very moving, prose style and in its multiple references to other literary texts, including Gabriela Mistral and Federico García Lorca, as well as the Bible.

What is more, *Las malas* contains a series of references to itself—its genesis, its composition, Sosa's own writing—that put the reader on an unstable footing. This is connected to and compounded by perhaps the strangest feature of the work: Sosa herself as narrator and author seems unsure about the status of *Las malas*: a blog that was deleted but then archived by a fan and returned to the author, revised for publication in what would quickly become an international hit. But even in its finished form, *Las malas* feels at once like a unified, coherent whole, and also as if something is missing—a novel that is somehow strange to itself. In short, if *Las malas* is a book in which tenderness appears in its various forms—in the vulnerability of the body; in the maternal

relationship between a trans mother and her child, or between a trans sex worker and her ‘chongo’ (tough guy, macho) boyfriend—it is a book whose own generic instability might also be regarded as a form of tenderness in its own right. I shall examine some examples to illustrate these points.

Trans Maternity

Much of *Las malas* details Sosa’s life, starting from the prologue by Juan Forn; Forn retells an early experience of paternal cruelty when the young Camila, aged four, then known as Cristian Omar, refuses to urinate standing up, much to the fury of Cristian’s father. But already Sosa’s career as a writer, and the status of the book, is hinted at: Cristian refuses the paternal demand, but can already write their full name.⁴² To be *travesti*, the novel claims, is to be literary. Sosa herself stated, in *El viaje inútil*, ‘Mi primer acto oficial de travestismo no fue salir a la calle vestida de mujer [. . .] fue a través de la escritura.’⁴³ So, readers should be wary, as this is a text deeply rooted in a particular socio-political context and life story, but fully engaged with the possibilities of literary creativity. In the earlier text Sosa explicitly links writing and maternity, the desire to write turning her into ‘una hembra viable para incubarlo’.⁴⁴

Sosa’s depiction of trans motherhood in *Las malas* is at once believable and fantastic. Motherhood is foregrounded in the book, from the epigraph from Gabriela Mistral through to the appearance, on the opening page, of a pregnant woman, ‘la única nacida mujer entre todas’, later identified as Laura; or in the mention early on of Sosa’s own birth and her mother’s two days of labour (*LM*, pp. 17, 49, 26). Nora Domínguez writes of a ‘pasión materna’ that is at the centre of the book.⁴⁵ *Las malas* offers an unconventional portrayal of motherhood centred on the figure of the *travesti* mother—embodied here by the character Tía Encarna. Encarna appears early in the work, as the group’s ‘aunt’ but as much a surrogate mother figure—older, wiser, with a welcoming house, and soon, with the discovery and adoption of her son El Brillo de los Ojos, who was abandoned in the park, a practising mother. She and her friends are contrasted, in a moment of free indirect style that captures a certain popular prejudice, with ‘la mala madre que lo [i.e. El Brillo] abandona en el parque’ (*LM*, p. 23).

Las malas is marked by its grasp of the nuances and contradictions that surround trans maternity. Motherhood is desired by all the *travestis*: ‘Todas

⁴² Juan Forn, ‘Prólogo’, in Camila Sosa Villada, *Las malas* (Buenos Aires: Tusquets, 2018), pp. 7–11 (p. 7).

⁴³ Sosa Villada, *Viaje*, p. 35.

⁴⁴ *Ibid.*, p. 13.

⁴⁵ Domínguez, *De donde vienen*, p. 564.

queríamos ser madres, era curioso hasta qué punto todas queríamos lo mismo' (LM, p. 64). We read of the collective care-giving of the *travesti* group, sharing the various aspects of child-rearing, but also that the act of taking a child, of adopting an abandoned baby, is a form of 'delirio' (LM, p. 23). Importantly, Sosa sets this in a socio-legal context in which trans motherhood is taboo and forbidden as police, media, and society are always ready to subject the *travesti* to violence; they are 'siempre dispuest[os] al linchamiento' (LM, p. 24). For society, 'La infancia y las travestis son incompatibles', an incompatibility that has religious overtones as a form of 'pecado' (LM, p. 24). Unknowability is important here—the threat perceived by a society that does not know what the trans mother is; but also in the response of Encarna, 'que no sabe qué es lo que está haciendo', when asked by a friend about her adoption and mothering (LM, p. 26). And this, too, is tied up in forms of madness, and in purely bodily responses, of 'una hembra que obedece a su cuerpo' (LM, p. 26). Nevertheless, the group persist with the 'delirio' of their collective childcare. Despite the social stigma, the trans community that mothers El Brillo is marked by its capacity for 'afecto', and in that house, as opposed to others, the boy 'era amado' (LM, p. 30).

Trans motherhood is a powerful agent of change in the book, in physical and emotional terms. The de facto adoption is the opportunity for the creation of new family links, 'de adjudicarse parentescos' (LM, p. 25). La Tía Encarna breast-'feeds' her son (although Sosa makes it clear that there is no actual milk on offer from a predominantly silicone breast) (LM, p. 25). As the narrator states, there is an emotional aspect at work here: 'Nadie en este mundo ha dormido nunca realmente si una travesti no le ha cantado una canción de cuna' (LM, p. 25). Encarna's role is also flexible (as might be expected), alternating between aunt and mother, 'como una madre, como una tía', and later, 'nuestra madre adoptiva' (LM, pp. 33, 40). She is also—echoing Pierce's work on Shock and Rodríguez—'madre de todos los monstruos' (LM, p. 47).⁴⁶ At the same time, they too need nurses ('nodrizas', or wet-nurses, is the word chosen by Sosa, with all its echoes of fairy tales) who take care of them and help them sleep.

Also present in the novel are various forms of labour, but especially parturition. We see this in the character of Laura (a pregnant sex worker in the group and eventually a biological mother) and the work of her partner Nadina, 'que era enfermero [*sic*] de día, [y] sabía todo acerca de un parto porque se había criado en el medio del monte y había ayudado a su madre a traer a varios hermanos al mundo, así como a cabras, a terneros y perros atravesados' (LM, p. 51). Nadina takes on a composite m/paternal role alongside Laura.

⁴⁶ See also Domínguez, *De donde vienen*, p. 432, on the depiction of monsters, mutations, and mothers in Argentine fiction in the 1980s.

Furthermore, as in Rose's example from Stryker (see above), La Tía Encarna speaks of her own parturition: "Yo también te [i.e. El Brillo] parí [. . .] pero por un camino de ramas y de sangre [. . .] Y yo no soy menos tu madre por no tener entre las piernas una herida abierta" (LM, p. 53). Later in the work, for legal and social reasons, Encarna disguises herself as a man, beard and all, for the purposes of her son's documentation and schooling. Outside, on the street or at the school gates, Encarna appears as Antonio Ruiz; behind closed doors, she is Encarna again. For El Brillo, 'Ella es mi mamá y mi papá' (LM, p. 186).

Tenderness: Writing the Body

Tenderness features prominently in *Las malas*, from Forn's prologue onward, though, as one might envisage, often in unexpected ways. The young Camila, in her first approach to the sex workers of Parque Sarmiento, Córdoba, is taken in by the more experienced *travestis* 'que la vieron tan tiernita y vulnerable'.⁴⁷ Tenderness too can be found in its most brutal, physical form: the vulnerability of the body to violence, being treated at times as little more than a punch bag or a piece of meat. We read of La Tía Encarna's many beatings: 'botines de policías y de clientes han jugado al fútbol con su cabeza y también con sus riñones'; later we read of the cuts from her time in jail, from self-wounding and fights (LM, pp. 19, 28). Tía Encarna bears within her '[una] pena [. . .] muy honda', from disappointments in love but, importantly, repeated beatings and other acts of violence (LM, p. 34). Later, we read advice from La Tía to her younger, less experienced colleagues about where best to let oneself be hit, in particular to avoid lasting kidney damage. Neither, she adds, should a *travesti* expect much sympathy from the medical profession (LM, p. 80).

The body, then, is ever present in the book, vulnerable but also adaptable out of necessity, at once flexible and hard, as the narrator puts it: 'Es como un líquido capaz de adaptarse a cualquier forma [. . .] El blindaje es total' (LM, p. 75). To be 'una prostituta' requires 'una anestesia total' (LM, p. 75). The most extreme example of this is the dead body, of which there are, tragically, several in the volume. One appears, that of 'una compañera muerta', in the same wasteland from which El Brillo is rescued (LM, p. 110). The political context is described: the group are on the run from the police, who regard murders such as this one with indifference or mockery. The body is found as Sosa and colleagues hide in the ditch, with a telling simile: 'nos quedamos inmóviles como cadáveres' (LM, p. 110).⁴⁸ As well as the physical proximity

⁴⁷ Forn, 'Prologo', p. 8.

⁴⁸ It is tempting to see a reference to Néstor Perlongher's most famous poem, 'Cadáveres', which

to death, in this case a corpse hidden in a black plastic bag and dumped in the park, trans life is never far in other ways from death: the threat of violence, risk of HIV/AIDS, and the wear and tear on the body that Sosa suggests makes *travesti* age seven times faster than the rest of the populace. Care of the dying, too, is a reality for the group: either members of their own, stripped of family or social support in their final days; or professionally (as healthcare workers); or in moments of crisis, exemplified best by La Machi, a recurring character in Sosa, healer-cum-paramedic-cum-shaman, who in *Las malas* tends a badly beaten and moribund *travesti* who is brought to her home (LM, p. 125).⁴⁹

This political context is important; later in the novel Sosa shares a list of the horrific crimes committed against *trans* folk (and in *Soy una tonta* this reaches dystopian proportions). Two terms should catch our eye here: ‘Hay cada vez más *desapariciones*. Hay un *monstruo* ahí afuera’ (LM, p. 214, emphasis added). The use of the term ‘disappearance’, almost synonymous with the crimes of the most recent civic–military dictatorship, foregrounds a violence against sexual minorities that transcends politico-historical watersheds, despite the political and social advances that may have occurred in Argentina in the 2000s.⁵⁰ At the same time, we have come to associate ‘monstrosity’ with the trans characters in the novel, as a positive alternative to normality and ‘decent’ civil society. But the monster can also be a source of cruelty and violence, feeding on the vulnerable.

Synonyms of tenderness and variants thereon appear, such as ‘dulzura’, with reference to the welcoming atmosphere of Encarna’s home, with its adoptive, adaptive family; ‘afecto’, too, is mentioned directly (LM, p. 26). Perhaps the saddest sequence in the work, prior to its tragic ending, is when Encarna hits her son, in part a result of stress brought on by a campaign of transphobic abuse from neighbours. But this inspires a reaction from Sosa’s narrator: hugging El Brillo, she writes of ‘el más puro ejercicio de la maternidad, eso que comparten todas las hembras del mundo: abrazar algo pequeño, darle afecto, aplacar el temor’ (LM, p. 203). The description of the act of maternal caregiving is striking, as is Sosa’s description of herself demonstrating this ‘maternal exercise’. And yet, once again we see the ambiguity that characterizes Sosa’s technique: the choice of a third-person plural to write of ‘hembras’, excluding herself from the mass of females just as she includes herself in their actions.

in part reflects on the risks facing trans and other sexual dissidents during the last civic–military dictatorship, albeit in a highly coded or stylized fashion. See Néstor Perlongher, ‘Cadáveres’, in *Poemas completos*, ed. by Roberto Echavarren (Buenos Aires: Seix Barral, 1997), pp. 109–23.

⁴⁹ La Machi reappears in the story ‘Seis tetas’ as the super-powered protector of the vulnerable community of runaways (*Soy una tonta*, pp. 171–209).

⁵⁰ On the ‘new disappearances’ see the collection of articles ‘Dossier: Ecologies of Disappearance Today’, ed. by Gabriel Gatti and David Casado-Neira, *Journal of Latin American Cultural Studies*, 29 (2020), 501–604 <<https://doi.org/10.1080/13569325.2021.1883571>>.

One of the most notable examples of *ternura* in *Las malas* comes in the shape of La Tía Encarna's lover/boyfriend, a sub-Saharan African refugee and one of the 'Hombres Sin Cabeza' who appear in both *Las malas* and *Soy una tonta*.⁵¹ These men are refugees from conflict, notable for 'su ternura, su sensibilidad y su disposición al juego'; at the same time, fleeing war and other forms of violence, like La Tía Encarna and her circle of protégées, 'Habían sufrido muchas penurias en la guerra, casi las mismas que las travestis en la calle' (*LM*, p. 37). The phrase 'headless man' is a way of referring to trauma, and how the men, wanting to forget past lives, 'sólo recordaban las cosas que habían sentido con la piel'; as a result they combine intense companionship and vulnerability in their relationships to La Tía Encarna and the gang (*LM*, p. 37). They are models of tenderness in its multiple meanings, and in positive and negative senses.

As well as being pregnant and the only 'born woman' in the group (to use Sosa's words), and later the only strictly biological mother, Laura is known for her 'ternura brutal', in particular the habit of grabbing and squeezing *travesti* penises. After the 'locura del parto', Laura and Nadina form perhaps the most unlikely couple in the book, both abandoning sex work and going to live together in the countryside (*LM*, p. 55). It is not quite as simple as Nadina 'abandoning' her trans identity; the relationship is a complex one, based on love and multiple roles: 'Laura se había enamorado del enfermero, pero también de la compañera de ruta, que venía en el mismo cuerpo' (*LM*, p. 55). Their love is marked by 'suavidad' and 'ternura' but also by an unknowability: Sosa confesses to the 'mareo' and 'escalofrío' that she and the other *travestis* feel when picturing the couple's lovemaking, and that 'no teníamos palabras para su historia' (*LM*, p. 56). Again, motherhood, tenderness, and the unknowable all rub shoulders.

This sense of tenderness is also found in the hard to define but also more positively marked experiences Sosa recounts from her sex work. One of the stranger examples features in the relationship that Sosa recounts with a particular client, a man with a mobility impairment who pays simply to sniff between her buttocks. This fetish aside, or perhaps included, '[sus] ojos [. . .] gritaban ternura', while Sosa describes his simultaneous physical difference and beauty (*LM*, p. 102). He is 'dulce y amargo', with a 'dulzura' that impregnates all around it, changing the air, and turning oxygen, in Sosa's works, into 'vectores de ternura' (*LM*, p. 102). In a rare sexual encounter, professional or otherwise, not marked by obvious violence, we see a moment of intense world-altering tenderness. Another happily remembered lover is also noted for his *ternura*—the zookeeper/hunter who pays the agreed fee and never causes her trouble: 'un animal amable y viril [. . .] te acariciaba con ternura'

⁵¹ It is also hard not to hear an echo of Lucrecia Martel's 2008 film *La mujer sin cabeza*.

(*LM*, pp. 155–56). This is worthy of note, for elsewhere Sosa observes that ‘los hombres no sólo mezquinan su ternura sino también el dinero que gastan en placer’ (*LM*, p. 204). This character is different. Although it is one of the most realist and realistic sequences in the book, a certain animality marks their encounters: the corpulent figure of the zookeeper; the presence of various animals, notably a ‘pobre camello’ obliged to watch the couple having sex; and Camila herself, ‘una perra caliente’ (*LM*, p. 157).

What makes the sequence more plausible yet while connecting it to the novel’s more fantastical streak is that it is followed immediately by another stage in the transformation of María la Muda into a bird. Humans turn into animals in a variety of ways—metaphorical, actual—in *Las malas*. If an aspect of tenderness is the crossing or vulnerability of boundaries, between bodies, for example, *trans* identity has already traced one crossing. In *Las malas* Sosa goes even further, beyond gender or identity, or even the living and the dead: trans existence is linked to the ability to turn *transparent*: ‘La velocidad de la caminata era consecuencia de nuestro afán por ser transparentes’ (*LM*, p. 143). A ‘solid’ or visible *travesti* inspires insults and violence (*LM*, p. 144). Sosa’s comments again blur the limits between the implausible or fantastical and practical reality—the need to avoid prying eyes or public violence.

Magic and Metafiction

Throughout *Las malas*, we read of fantastical, magical, and, more broadly, implausible incidents and characters. Most striking is the figure of María la Muda, who begins, quite early in the work and for no clear reason, to sprout feathers. She despairs, communicating with her friends via notes: ‘KOMBO BOY ATRABAJAR’ and, notably, ‘SOI UN MOSTRO’ (*sic*: *LM*, pp. 86, 87). The narrator refers to her ‘destino de pájaro’, describing an eventual complete transformation as the book progresses; later she is referred to as ‘flaca, negra, con los brazos cubiertos de esos canutillos de plumas [. . .] una escena de pesadilla’ (*LM*, pp. 87, 107). The transformation is told with the same tone as the memoir or *crónica* sections, once again calling into question the genre, indeed the status, of the work itself, in which there is little stylistic distinction between literary modes. By the end of the book María is described, quite matter-of-factly, as ‘la pajarita enjaulada’ (*LM*, p. 215). The sequence calls to mind ideas of ‘shared forms’ explored in Gabriel Giorgi’s work on animality and biopower, or what Pierce calls, with reference to Giorgi, ‘the unstable boundary between the human and the animal, the human and the machine, and the human and the monster’.⁵² Pierce finds another example in the work of the Argentine trans activist Susy Shock, ‘who describes their [*sic*] gender as

⁵² Gabriel Giorgi, *Forma comunes: animalidad, cultura, biopolítica* (Buenos Aires: Eterna Cadencia, 2014); Pierce, ‘I Monster’, p. 307.

not human but “colibrí” (hummingbird).⁵³ Monsters are polyvalent in Sosa’s work, not innately sources of optimism (see above), and clearly a fount of despair for María. But, as Pierce puts it, “monstering” [. . .] has become a crucial form of [. . .] resistance to neoliberal politics of inclusion and recognition in Latin America and of opening new possibilities of imagining collective belonging.⁵⁴ Sosa’s literary trope is to tell this story with a (mostly) straight face in a work often marked by its compelling realism.

A further source of verisimilitude is Sosa’s tracing of a socio-political context. Also from well within the realms of the supernatural is the character Natalí; ‘era la séptima hija varón [*sic*] en su familia y las noches de luna llena se convertía en lobizona’ (*LM*, p. 103). The werewolf in Spanish is more commonly a ‘hombre- (or mujer-)lobo/a’; *lobisón* is another term, but the *lobisón* recalls a figure in Guaraní mythology, also found more widely in popular beliefs in Argentina and Paraguay. Natalí, the narrator notes, becomes a *lobizona* (feminine). This is set against a historical reality: that seventh sons were made godchildren of the president, an unofficial custom that became more regular under Juan Domingo Perón and continues today.⁵⁵ Alfonsín was a Radical Party president, the first to be democratically elected after the civic-military dictatorship (1976–83); the specific detail lends credibility to the unbelievable fantasy—a typical technique of the magical realist novel. Trans history, Argentine politics, and literary imagination are inseparable here.

At the same time, some of these fantasies are marked by a note of doubt from the narrator. The songs of the Hombre Sin Cabeza, accompanied by La Tía Encarna, summon dark birds to listen, perched on walls and balconies. In itself, this is perfectly plausible; later, though, their songs cause a suspected or possible miracle as a statue of the Virgin of Guadalupe appears to cry. Sosa vacillates between interpretations: ‘Nunca supimos si fue la humedad de aquel día o la manifestación de la divinidad lo que obró el milagro, lo cierto es que fue apabullante y nos estrujó el corazón de belleza’ (*LM*, p. 42). Cultivated uncertainty, ambiguity, and unknowability all feature throughout the novel, particularly at its moments of most heightened emotion. A related technical feature, again shared with certain works of magical realist fiction, is its blurring of the limits between the literal and the figurative: readers are left unsure whether to read metaphors as metaphors or as events in a fantastical world. Faced with the threat of violence during one encounter, Sosa

⁵³ Pierce, ‘I Monster’, p. 313.

⁵⁴ *Ibid.*, p. 305.

⁵⁵ ‘Alberto Fernández será padrino de un séptimo hijo varón’, *La Nación*, 16 July 2022 <<https://www.lanacion.com.ar/sociedad/alberto-fernandez-sera-padrino-de-un-septimo-hijo-varon-nid16072022/>> [accessed 20 July 2023]. The law in question is number 20,843, passed in 1974: Honorable Congreso de la Nación Argentina <<https://www.argentina.gob.ar/normativa/nacional/ley-20843-158477>> [accessed 20 July 2023].

states: 'Abro las branquias, erizo la pelambre y saco las uñas' (*LM*, p. 168). Humans do not have gills, but our hairs can stand on end, and we can partially hide our claws, or nails (in a fist). Do we read this metaphorically in whole or in part (or not at all)? Again, the socially and physically plausible rubs shoulders with the imaginative, the literal with the metaphorical. Later, La Tía Encarca is described as lactating. After a particularly humiliating encounter, Sosa goes to see her. In a strange act of therapy, Encarna slaps Sosa and then bares a breast which, when squeezed, releases 'un hilo de leche [...] como una lágrima entre sus dedos' (*LM*, p. 134). The tears mirror Sosa's own (she describes herself as 'un mar de lágrimas') and remind us of La Difunta Correa (the popular saint who, it is said, continued to provide milk to her infant child despite having died). Encarna then invites her to spend Christmas with this new, alternative family. At this stage there is little we can do but accept as fact what we have read, but quickly a prose flourish suggests otherwise: 'Oh, nodriza Encarna. Oh, milagro de tus pechos. Oh, Difunta Correa de tetas de aceite de avión' (*LM*, p. 134). The use of various non-medical substances (industrial silicone, aviation oil) for bodily modification is a repeated feature of this work (and other trans memoirs—witness several sequences in the Chilean Pedro Lemebel's *Loco afán*);⁵⁶ at the same time, the reference to miracles and popular saints adds a further note of ambiguity, and places the incident in an uncertain space between memoir and fantasy.

Towards the end of the book, it is even suggested to us that the whole story is in fact the product of a child's imagination:

Cuando logramos entrar vemos al niño tallando en madera los animales que hemos sido: mujeres pájaros, mujeres lobos, mujeres tristes, mujeres valientes, toda nuestra mitología tallada en esas estatuillas que el niño crea en su reclusión. (*LM*, p. 208)

This leads us to another important point: the eminently artistic, indeed *literary*, nature of *Las malas*. *Las malas* echoes and refashions many literary genres, including Latin American transvestite chronicles (for example, Lemebel's writing), fairy tales, the horror story, and also 'narratives of motherhood' or 'la serie de las madres', as Domínguez calls a series of fictions and writings with a long tradition in Argentine history, from Esteban Echeverría's *La cautiva* (1837) to stories about the Mothers of Plaza de Mayo and tales of Eva Perón as the mother of the nation.⁵⁷ *Las malas* begins with a literary quotation drawn precisely from Gabriela Mistral, from the poem 'Todas íbamos a ser reinas'. Mistral, whose own queer life and poetics have been the subject of a number of revisionist studies in recent years, foremost that of Licia Fiol

⁵⁶ Pedro Lemebel, *Loco afán* (Barcelona: Anagrama, 2000).

⁵⁷ Domínguez, *De donde vienen*.

Matta, was for decades regarded as an icon of literary motherhood.⁵⁸ Sosa introduces an ambiguity in what is already a poem full of layers and nuance: ‘reina’ is at once the literal queen whom the girls in Mistral’s poem aspire to be and a (multilingual) slang term for queer or trans. Mistral reappears later, too: Encarna (in one of the versions of her life that she tells) had learnt her poems by heart as a youth (*LM*, p. 29). A central incident in the novel, the discovery of the baby, offers further opportunity for a literary reference, to Oscar Wilde’s *The Importance of Being Earnest* (1895), as the child who will be El Brillo is taken away in ‘la cartera’—or a handbag (*LM*, p. 21). This is at once a plausible and realist detail and yet too close to the well-known quip from a famous bisexual author to be overlooked as a literary intertext. Federico García Lorca is another recurring presence: ‘para La Tía Encarna todas las travestis éramos Yerma’, a reference to his ‘rural tragedy’ and its title character (*LM*, p. 54). Later Sosa cites *Doña Rosita la Soltera* (*LM*, p. 130). Central to this aspect of the work is the very literary nature of the *travesti*, as Sosa herself puts it: ‘¿Pensaron alguna vez que la poesía podía tener una forma tan concreta?’⁵⁹

As Juan Forn notes in his prologue, the genesis of *Las malas* was somewhat atypical. It began life as a handwritten diary, which the young Camila then typed up at a local cybercafé during her university days in the early 2000s. When she began her acting career, she deleted the blog.⁶⁰ Luckily, one might say, a fan downloaded or copied all the posts, and with Sosa’s star as a stage and screen actress on the rise, sent her the copy—the origin of *Las malas* and another example, for Forn, of the ‘alchemy’ at work in its pages.⁶¹ Sections of the novel—for example, Sosa’s reflections on her time at university—have the tone of a standard literary memoir (*LM*, pp. 127–30), and this links to the position or status of the *travesti* in Sosa’s work: ‘algo muy difícil de explicar’, she writes (*LM*, p. 169). There are incidents, too, that exist between the original blog and the text we can read today. Sosa tells of an encounter with a once much-loved *cuarteto* singer and popular entertainer; afterwards, she writes, ‘me hice un té y me senté a escribir, algo que hacía a menudo al finalizar mis noches de ronda. Pero no alcancé a escribir una página’ (*LM*, p. 177).⁶² She was, we discover, interrupted by another client. Where, then, does this incident fit in terms of the composition of the

⁵⁸ Licia Fiol Matta, *A Queer Mother for the Nation: The State and Gabriela Mistral* (Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press, 2002).

⁵⁹ Cited in Forn, ‘Prólogo’, p. 11.

⁶⁰ *Ibid.*, p. 8.

⁶¹ *Ibid.*, p. 9. Sosa is referred to as an *actriz* in most biographies; although it has become common practice to use the gender-neutral term ‘actor’ in English to refer to performers of all genders, its echoes of the term *actor* in Spanish would have the unfortunate effect of mismatching with Sosa’s own gender identity.

⁶² *Cuarteto* is a popular style of energetic big-band dance music in Córdoba and other provinces

work? The details—left vague, one imagines, for legal and other reasons—the inclusion of memories from further back in time of happy family parties and dances, and the question of *when* this section was composed: all this remains nebulous or unanswered.

As in Marina Yuszczuk's *Madre soltera*, self-negation or disavowal is another feature of *Las malas* that undermines its position as an orthodox memoir or *crónica*.⁶³ Sosa writes of sunbathing one summer's day, lying on the grass and using Coca-Cola as tanning lotion. In the next paragraph, this is contradicted: 'No. En realidad somos nocturnas, para qué negarlo. No salimos de día. Los rayos del sol nos debilitan' (*LM*, p. 117). While the passage flirts with fantasy and the Gothic—the vampire novel, in particular—Sosa goes on to explain that the sun reveals scars and imperfections, better hidden at night. At the same time we are presented with an incident told straight-faced but which we almost immediately must discount. Later on the same page, however, Sosa states that they *do* go sunbathing. While the incident may seem trivial, it is part of the innate literariness of the work, and of a characteristic of trans life as a whole, as written by Sosa: 'Estamos ahí para ser escritas. Para ser eternas' (*LM*, p. 118). Lives sketched as fleeting, vulnerable, contradictory, and brief—at times barely *liveable*—achieve some permanence as a literary creation.⁶⁴ The last act of the novel is for the 'Bad Girls' to disappear: 'Nosotras, las olvidadas, ya no tenemos nombre. Es como si nunca hubiéramos estado ahí' (*LM*, p. 220). Readers may hear an echo of Luis Buñuel's cinema; they may also see this as underscoring the innately literary, and so at once permanent and fleeting, nature of Sosa's characters, including even herself, as portrayed in *Las malas*.

Conclusion

In *Las malas* we witness an example of narrative tenderness: the porosity between this and works by Sosa and others; the uncertain shifting between genres and forms; and the description of tenderness in all its forms, from affective contact that blurs the boundary between self and other, to the violence that threatens the integrity of the body and the subject that inhabits and exceeds it. Camila Sosa Villada not only inaugurates a new way of writing about trans characters, fed in turn by a strong tradition of *literatura travesti*.

of the interior; its most famous exponent is the singer Juan Carlos Jiménez Rufino, better known as 'La Mona Giménez'.

⁶³ See also Ben Bollig, *Politics and Public Space in Contemporary Argentine Poetry: The Lyric and the State* (New York: Palgrave Macmillan, 2016), pp. 213–24.

⁶⁴ On 'liveable' trans lives see Kathleen Lennon, 'Making Life Livable: Transsexuality and Bodily Transformation', *Radical Philosophy*, 140 (November–December 2006) <<https://www.radicalphilosophy.com/article/making-life-livable>> [accessed 20 July 2023].

She also proposes a conception of literature based on a trans ethic: 'Mi primer acto oficial de travestismo fue escribir' (*LM*, p. 10). For Sosa, all writing is a form of transvestism, and all transvestism is, in turn, a form of nudity and vulnerability. *Las malas* foregrounds this with its vivid and moving depiction of the tenderness at the heart of trans maternity.

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